Domestic Abuse Statement [i]

Crossway Bible Church has affirmed this domestic abuse statement to protect intimate partners, children, and others residing in the homes of our church members and attenders when domestic abuse occurs within those homes.

Abuse occurs when a person in a position of greater influence uses his or her personal capacities or power to diminish the personal capacities of those under their influence in order to control them.

Because God made people as embodied souls, these personal capacities are both physical and spiritual. Abuse is identified from two directions: (1) the manipulative intent and behavioral forcefulness of the one in a position of influence, and (2) the diminishing effect on those under his or her influence.

- Abuse is an assault upon the image of God in another human being.

- Abuse usually occurs in a pattern that is typically increasing in frequency and/or intensity.

- Abuse is intentional, though the abuser may not be self-aware enough to recognize the intentions of his or her heart. Abuse is never perpetrated by accident.

- Abuse is about the misuse of power to control or manipulate another for selfish gain. It is an act of oppression.

- Abuse can involve physical, emotional, verbal, sexual, economic, spiritual, or psychological means. Sadly, the abuse is often perpetrated through a combination of these.

- The goal of abuse is self-gratification—to get what one wants at the expense of another.

Domestic violence in any form—physical, sexual, emotional, economic, psychological or spiritual—is an assault upon the image of God in a fellow human being, and is therefore an assault upon God Himself.

When it is between a husband and a wife, it further violates the one-flesh covenantal relationship that God established. Under no circumstance is abuse ever justified. Neither is it ever the fault of the victim.

Domestic abuse severely damages relationships and often destroys the relationship beyond repair. An act of abuse is never an act of Christian love.

Christ's self-giving love seeks to encourage the flourishing of the individual, while domestic abuse seeks to limit the victim's capacities through dominance, replacing love with fear.

Given this acknowledgement, the elders of Crossway Bible Church affirm the following:

- Domestic abuse in all its forms is sinful and incompatible with the Christian faith and a Christian way of living.

- All abuse is spiritually damaging for both the victim and the abuser, and has collateral damage that extends to children, extended family, and close friendships.

- Domestic abuse is a serious problem which occurs in church families as well as in wider society.

- Domestic abuse is not primarily an anger problem, a mental disorder problem, a marriage problem, the victim’s problem, or even simply a legal problem, but rather a sin problem.

- Statistically, domestic abuse is primarily perpetrated by men, against the very people whom God has given these men to protect and shepherd—women and children.

Given these realities and our responsibility under the Lord to protect the flock at Crossway, the elders of Crossway Bible Church state the following intentions:

- We intend to listen to, take seriously, support, and care for those affected by domestic abuse.

- We want to urge abused persons to consider their own safety and that of family members first and to seek help from the church, competent counseling,

and legal resources, to bring healing to the individuals and, if possible, to the marriage relationship.

- We do not intend to encourage marriage counseling in cases of domestic abuse until both parties and their counselors agree that they are ready for marriage counseling.

- We will report suspected abuse of children, the elderly, and the disabled to the proper authorities without delay, in accordance with the laws of Texas.

- We endeavor to call abusers to repent and wait patiently for them to demonstrate consistent fruit of repentance before acknowledging repentance.

- We will discipline abusers and excommunicate them from the church if they are unrepentant.

- We desire to work with local domestic violence support agencies, and to learn from them and support them in appropriate ways.

- We will teach that domestic abuse is a sin.

- We will teach what it means to be male and female image-bearers of God, equal in value, dignity and worth.

- We intend to train elders, small group leaders, and other ministry leaders in an appropriate domestic abuse awareness and response training and update this training regularly.

- We want to make wise use of competent counselors and trained professionals to encourage best practices and keep church members and leadership trained on and informed about domestic abuse.

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[i] Adapted from Jeremy Pierre and Greg Wilson, *When Home Hurts: A Guide for Responding Wisely to Domestic Abuse in Your Church.* Christian Focus Publications. (pp. 264-267).